JAMES 5 AND ANOINTING WITH OIL

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If people get sick, James **5**:14-15 urges them to call the elders of the church to pray over them and anoint them with olive oil in the name of the Lord. This text raises two issues: (1) whether the procedure is restrictive or positive (cp. commandment *vs.* advice), which amounts to precedent *vs.* example; and (2) whether it is miracle or answered prayer. In the first issue, "restrictive" commandment means that specifying this way eliminates other ways; "positive" commandment means this is a good way to deal with it. If the commandment is non-restrictive, it must be an "example" (one way of approaching God for healing) rather than a "precedent" to be followed always and henceforth. These variables affect the propriety and necessity of using olive oil today for healing, of calling a plurality of church elders, and of accompanying the procedure with prayer.

I. Example and Precedent

What James describes is evidently example rather than set form. He does not lay down a necessary formula for getting the results. A "formula" would require that the sick person do the calling, that he call the elders rather than general church members, that he call elders rather than one of them, that they must anoint with oil, that they use olive oil rather than some other oil or ointment, that they do so explicitly in the name of the Lord, and that they pray. James does not mention laying on hands, which occurs in some accounts of New Testament healings.

The following considerations tell against James' instructions as a permanent set form. (1) The number of New Testament healing cases is too small to set a precedent for anointing with oil. Of the many miraculous and non-miraculous healings, only two texts mention olive oil: this text and the Mission of the Twelve in Mark's account (**6**:13). Not much of a pattern can be deduced from two cases (although both involve sets of cases).

Furthermore, (2) the New Testament examples are not uniform. No account of a specific healing mentions anointing. Many include laying on of hands, which is not mentioned here. If the examples are not uniform, they do not set precedent.

(3) The nature of the case allows the effect to come in various ways. Christian processes are not formulas, because they occur with a personal God rather than a legal or natural operation. Christianity has no magic words or rituals that activate impersonal forces. Human requests are not causes; they pass through the will of a Person who answers freely by promise (cp. Romans **5**:15-16 > Exodus **33**:19).

The lack of uniformity means that James **5** does not provide a biblical basis for "extreme unction" or "last rites." James envisions more than terminal illness. In fact, he pictures a standard situation that does not involve death-bed circumstances: *"the Lord will raise them up."*

II. Miracle *vs*. Answered Prayer

Although Mark **6**:13 connects oil with miraculous healing, it seems not to be the kind of healing James **5** enjoins.

(1) James would be implying that every congregation had elders with the gift of healing, which is uncertain from the evidence available on the diversity of gifts in the New Testament.

(2) Instances of miraculous healing do not always include prayer (Mark **2**:1-12; Acts **3**; *etc*.).

(3) Most importantly, the context in James **5** deals primarily with prayer. In fact, the text identifies *"the prayer of faith"* as what saves the sick.

(4) The author associates his exhortation with Elijah's prayer that it not rain for three and a half years in Israel and then that it would rain.

(5) James does not mention imposition of hands.

(6) The promise of healing is no stronger here than with answered prayer: *"Whatever you ask in prayer, believing, you will receive"* (Matthew **21**:[21-]22; cp. **17**:19-20; Mark **10**:23-24; John **15**:16b; **16**:23-24). Whereas miracles are uniformly successful (to provide evidential value), answered prayers are not. Nevertheless, statements about answered prayer are made in absolute terms that assume all the appropriate considerations:

that the request harmonizes with God's will (John **14**:13-14; **15**:7; 1 John **5**:14),
that requesters are doing their part,
that their motives for asking are right (James **4**:3),
that they are obeying God in other respects (1 John **3**:22),
that they are treating other people right (1 Peter **3**:7),
that they are sincere (Luke **18**:8; **20**:46-47),
that they have sufficient faith (Matthew **21**:21; James **1**:6-7),
that they are forgiving others (Matthew **6**:15), and
that receiving the request would not reduce their growth potential (Acts **4**:29-31; 1 Corinthians **10**:13b; **12**:8-9).

James' promise that God *"will raise them up"* does not move the process from prayer to miracle. With either answered prayer or express miracle, the process cannot be uniform, or no Christian would ever die. For that reason, it is important to note cases where people were not healed by prayer (2 Corinthians **12**:7-10), and miracle was not even attempted (1 Timothy **5**:23; 2 Timothy **4**:20).

III. The Purpose of Using Oil

James does not explain the reason for olive oil; we can only infer the reason from other anointings. In Jewish religion and culture, anointing was a medicine, a cosmetic, and a symbol of consecration.

(1) The Samaritan illustrated medicinal usage when he put oil and wine in the traveler's wounds (Luke **10**:34; cp. Isaiah **1**:6; note Revelation **3**:18).

(2) Cosmetic usage appears in Esther **2**:12 when Esther was being prepared to enter the house of King Ahasuerus (cp. Song of Solomon **1**:3; Judith **10**:3-4; **16**:8). By extension, pouring oil on the head or feet of guests was a gesture of hospitality. In two similar instances, a woman poured oil on the head or feet of Jesus while he was reclining at dinner (on the head according to Matthew **26**:6-13 = Mark **14**:3-9; on the feet in Luke **7**:36-50; John **12**:1-8 + **11**:2). In response to criticism from his disciples, Jesus interpreted her act as a preparation for his soon burial (Matthew **26**:8-13 = Mark **14**:4-9; John **12**:4-8; cp. Mark **16**:1). A third extension of

cosmetic usage signaled the end of mourning (2 Samuel **12**:20; **14**:2; Matthew **6**:17). Mourners indicated mourning by not putting on the customary oil.

(3) Appointment usage was with *kings* (Judges **9**:15; 1 Samuel **10**:1; **16**:3; 1 Kings **1**:39; 2 Kings **9**:6; **11**:12; Psalm **89**:20), including the *Messiah* as king (Psalm **2**:2; **45**:7 = Acts **4**:26-27; cp. Acts **10**:38); *priests* (Exodus **38**:41; **29**:7; Leviticus **8**:12; **21**:10), *prophets* (1 Kings **19**:16; Isaiah **61**:1 = Luke **4**:18; cp. Genesis **20**:7; 1 Chronicles **16**:22; Psalm **105**:15), and more generally *highly favored ones* (Zechariah **4**:14). Setting aside to a specific usage—sanctification—included the dedication of *objects* for temple ritual (Exodus **30**:33; Leviticus **8**:10-11). Relative to privileged appointment and hospitality, anointing with oil symbolized blessing and joy (Psalm **23**:5; **92**:10), and by extension it symbolized the Holy Spirit (Acts **10**:38; 1 John **2**:20, 27). When "Messiah" (the "Anointed One") is appointed to office, his anointing is not with oil but with the Spirit—as at his baptism (Matthew **3**:16 = Mark **1**:10 = Luke **3**:22 = John **1**:22-24).

(a) In keeping with cosmetic usage, anointing with oil in James **5** could indicate confidence in being healed by *preparing to re-enter public life*. (b) In medicinal usage, anointing may symbolize the *healing* that will take place. It is doubtful that oil is for therapeutic value, because James is speaking of sickness in general, not of external wounds in particular, where the oil itself might facilitate healing. (c) The oil may symbolize the *blessing* that healing brings. Finally, (d) it may serve as a symbol of the *Holy Spirit* who blesses with healing.

IV. The Propriety of Contemporary Usage

If the anointing in James **5** connects with cosmetic usage, it was a cultural practice modern western societies no longer follow. Since it is example rather than precedent, again anointing with oil need not be standard practice or us. If James is speaking of miracle *vs*. answered prayer, the propriety of contemporary usage depends on a person's conclusion about the duration of miracle. Even then, anointing would not have to be precedent to guarantee success.

In the final analysis, the use of olive oil in requests for healing appears to be a matter of taste, a matter of opinion, something not forbidden yet not required.